

Read: Galatians 5:1-6

Freed From Chains

Galatians 5:1

It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not let yourselves be burdened again by a yoke of slavery.

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Did you know archaeologists have actually found real iron chains from Bible times? In one place called Great Casterton in England, they dug up heavy rusty ankle shackles that Roman guards used on prisoners. Picture having your legs tied together with heavy metal cuffs. Every step—clank, clank—would remind you that you couldn't move freely.

That's kind of what sin feels like. It's like wearing invisible chains around your heart. You want to do what's right, but you trip up and feel weighted down by guilt.

God's rules are good. If everyone kept them—no lying, no meanness, no selfishness—this world would be awesome! But nobody keeps them perfectly. The harder we try, the more we notice how far we fall short. It's like carrying a backpack full of bricks called "mistakes." It's like invisible chains inside our hearts.

When Paul wrote to the Galatians, some teachers were adding more rules—extra food laws, special rituals—and saying, "If you really want God to love you, do all of these." That made people feel trapped again! Their hearts got tired and worried—'Am I good enough yet?'

So Paul reminded them, "It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and don't let yourselves be chained again by a yoke of slavery" (Galatians 5:1). And again, "The only thing that counts is faith expressing itself through love" (Galatians 5:6).

Here's the awesome twist—the great "Uno Reverse" move! Jesus already kept every rule perfectly. Then he took all our sins to the cross, and when he rose again, he snapped sin's chains forever! You don't have to wonder if you're good enough—Jesus already was, for you.

So now we get to live free! Think of God's commands not as heavy chains, but as a path to show love.

- At school, maybe you sit with someone who's alone.
- At home, maybe you share your dessert or say sorry first.

When you do, you're walking free in Jesus' love.

Without Jesus, life feels chained—heavy, stuck, afraid. With Jesus, we're free, forgiven, and full of joy!

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for Younger Children

- What's something heavy you've tried to carry, like a giant backpack or bag of sports gear? How did it feel?
- How can you show someone Jesus' love, like sharing?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- When Paul says Jesus sets us free, what do you think he means? Free from what?
- How could you "use your freedom" to show Jesus' love—at school, at home, or with friends?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- Agree or Disagree: Since Jesus broke the chains of sin, we can just do whatever we want. (*Why might that be wrong?*)
- If a friend feels like they'll never be good enough, how could you help them see that Jesus already made them free?

Closing Prayer:

Dear heavenly Father, thank you for Jesus, who broke the chains of our sins with his love. Help us live freely, sharing your love with others every day. In Jesus' name, Amen.